

DARK SQUARES

Book One

Season One

A Cinematic Episode Manuscript

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Complete Book One Manuscript

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Episode 1

The Woods

Before the Rocks, before Lucky's studio, before Sarah, before the party that would carry a name nobody wanted to say out loud, there was the Woods.

The Woods was not just a neighborhood. It was a classroom, a warning, a playground, and a test. It taught boys how to run, how to hide, how to laugh when nothing was funny, and how to read a face before a word came out of a mouth.

Manny and Keith grew up there in a four-family building where privacy was thin and sound traveled through walls like secrets. Their apartment sat low in the building, close to the basement hallway, close to the laundry room, close enough to the back entrance that footsteps could change the mood of the whole day.

Their mother, Ella Mae, had one rule that stood above every other rule.

Do not bring drama or the streets to this house.

She did not say it like a suggestion. She said it like scripture. The house was the one place where the world was supposed to stop at the door. Whatever happened outside stayed outside. Whatever pride, disrespect, misunderstanding, or trouble followed a person home had to die before it reached her living room.

Manny understood that rule better than anyone. He was the oldest. Keith was his little brother. Four years separated them, but in the Woods, four years could feel like a whole lifetime. Manny was not Keith's father, but he carried pieces of that job anyway.

When Ella Mae worked late, the boys had more freedom than they should have had. The neighborhood opened up after the streetlights came on. The night belonged to the curious, the brave, and the ones who thought nobody could catch them.

They rode bikes. They played stickball and basketball. They explored alleys, empty lots, and places grown folks told them to stay away from. They were children, but the city rarely treated children like children.

Music was already there, even then. Coming from car windows. From radios on porches. From older boys carrying boom boxes. Hip-hop was not background noise to them. It was weather. It was the sound of growing up.

Keith followed crowds easily. People liked him. He could make anybody laugh, and that gift made him welcome in places Manny did not always want him to be. Manny watched him carefully, not because Keith was weak, but because Keith was magnetic. Some boys attract friends. Some attract trouble. Keith had a way of attracting both.

In those days, the Woods felt bigger than the whole world.

They had no idea they would one day move away from it.

They had no idea the Woods would follow them anyway.

Episode 2

Monday

Monday started like a regular day until somebody knocked on the apartment door.

Not a polite knock.

A testing knock.

Keith looked up first. Manny froze where he stood. Kizzy, their protective little dog, lifted her head and gave one sharp bark.

The boys at the door were not there for homework. They were not there to play. They had followed Keith downstairs after some words upstairs, and now they were standing outside Ella Mae's apartment trying to bring the street to the one place it was forbidden to enter.

Manny looked toward the clock.

Their mother would be home in less than thirty minutes.

That mattered more than the boys outside. More than pride. More than fear. If Ella Mae walked in and found trouble at her door, the punishment would last longer than any fight.

Keith whispered, "Don't open it."

Manny grabbed the bat anyway.

The knock came again.

"We know y'all in there."

Manny opened the door just enough to be seen and not enough to let them in.

Three boys stood in the hallway. One had his hands in his pockets. Another leaned forward like he wanted Manny to swing first. The third kept looking toward the stairwell.

Manny did not raise his voice.

"Go home."

One laughed. "We ain't scared of you."

"I didn't ask if you was scared. I said go home."

For a moment, nobody moved.

Then, from the back of the building, the outside door opened.

Manny heard it.

The boys in the hallway heard it too.

Footsteps.

Ella Mae.

The boys outside suddenly became less interested in being tough. One backed toward the stairs. The other two followed. By the time Ella Mae came through the hallway, all she heard was a door closing upstairs.

Manny shut his door and slid the bat behind the couch.

Keith sat down fast, trying to look normal.

Kizzy paced in a circle, still suspicious.

Ella Mae opened the door with her work bag on her shoulder and looked from one son to the other.

"Why y'all so quiet?"

Manny shrugged. "We good."

Keith nodded too quickly. "Yeah."

Ella Mae looked toward the ceiling, where the sound of running feet had faded.

She knew something had happened.

She also knew her boys had made sure it did not happen in her house.

So she kept it smooth.

"Wash your hands," she said. "Dinner almost ready."

Manny and Keith looked at each other.

Neither one laughed until much later.

Even then, the laugh was nervous.

They had been close. Too close.

Episode 3

Junkyard Kings

There was a junkyard near the alley that felt like a secret kingdom.

To grown folks, it was a place full of used cars, broken glass, rust, and warning signs. To Manny and Keith, it was imagination with wheels.

They climbed into old cars and pretended they were driving across the country. They sat behind steering wheels that no longer turned and shifted gears connected to nothing. Keith always wanted the fastest car. Manny always wanted the cleanest one.

"This one mine," Keith said, sliding across a torn leather seat.

"That one ain't even got a door."

"Don't need one. Race car."

Manny laughed and climbed into a faded sedan with a cracked dashboard. "This mine. Smooth."

"That look like something a teacher drive."

"A rich teacher."

They laughed so loud birds scattered from the fence.

The junkyard was one of the few places where Keith belonged only to Manny. No Chucky. No older boys. No crowd pulling him somewhere else. Just two brothers making a world out of what other people threw away.

Sometimes Manny would tap rhythms on the steering wheel. Keith would rap nonsense over the beat without knowing he was practicing for a future that had not found him yet.

"You always making noise," Manny said.

"You always making beats."

"That ain't a beat."

"It is when I rap on it."

Manny shook his head, but he kept tapping.

They stayed until the light changed.

That was the rule in the neighborhood. When the streetlights came on, you better already be close to home. The only nights they got away with staying out late were the nights Ella Mae had to work overtime, and those nights always felt dangerous and free at the same time.

On the way home, Kizzy trotted behind them like she was part of the crew. She barked at shadows, chased leaves, and made Keith swear she could see ghosts.

"She don't see no ghosts," Manny said.

"Then why she barking at nothing?"

"Because she crazy like you."

Keith laughed and ran ahead.

Manny watched him go, smiling.

He did not know yet that these ordinary days would become sacred later. He did not know that one day he would give anything to ride through that alley again with his little brother and that dog, pretending broken things could still take them somewhere.

Episode 4

The Graveyard Bet

The bet started over nothing.

Most dangerous ideas did.

Somebody said Keith was scared. Keith said he was not. Manny said everybody was scared of something. Keith asked Manny what he was scared of. Manny said not the graveyard.

That was all it took.

By the time night settled over the Woods, the bet had become official. Whoever backed out had to admit the other one was braver.

Keith would rather walk through fire than admit that.

Kizzy came with them because Kizzy went wherever the boys went if no one stopped her. She trotted between them with her head up, alert, proud, and completely unaware she was supposed to be protecting them from a dare they created themselves.

The graveyard looked different at night. During the day, it was grass and stones and quiet. At night, it became something else. Trees leaned like they were listening. The wind moved low across the ground. Every shadow looked like it had a reason.

Keith whispered, "This was your idea."

"It was your mouth."

"You older."

"You bet."

Kizzy stopped.

Both boys stopped with her.

"Why she stop?" Keith whispered.

Manny swallowed. "Because you stopped."

"I stopped because she stopped."

Kizzy growled at the darkness between two headstones.

That was enough.

Keith took off running.

Manny ran after him.

Kizzy barked once and ran past both of them like she had been waiting for the race to start.

They did not stop until they reached the street.

Keith bent over, laughing and gasping.

"You ran first!"

"You ran because I moved."

"No, you ran."

"Kizzy ran first."

They both looked at the dog.

Kizzy stood in the street, tail wagging, proud of herself.

The brothers laughed so hard they had to sit on the curb.

The graveyard bet became one of those stories Keith told differently every time. In his version, Manny screamed. In Manny's version, Keith almost cried. In Kizzy's version, if she could have told it, she saved them both.

The truth did not matter.

The memory did.

Episode 5

Steve's Turntables

Steve lived across town and had something Manny had only seen from a distance.

Real turntables.

Not a radio. Not a tape deck. Not somebody tapping on a steering wheel in a junkyard.

Turntables.

The first Saturday Manny walked into Steve's room, he stopped at the door like he had entered a church. Records leaned against the wall. Speakers sat in the corners. Wires ran across the floor in a way that looked confusing until Steve touched them. Then everything made sense.

Steve smiled. "You ever blend records?"

Manny shook his head.

"You wanna learn?"

Manny nodded before he could pretend to be cool.

Steve placed his hands on the equipment carefully, like he was teaching Manny how to hold something alive. He showed him how to listen for the beat, how to count without counting, how to feel when one song was ready to meet another.

Manny was awkward at first. Too early. Too late. Too fast. Too scared to touch the record with confidence.

Steve did not laugh.

"Again," he said.

So Manny tried again.

Then again.

Then again.

By the fourth Saturday, the mistakes were still there, but something else had arrived.

Instinct.

Manny started to hear the space between songs. He started to understand that music was not just sound. It was timing. It was patience. It was control.

That made sense to him.

Basketball had rhythm too. A crossover. A pass. A shot released before the defender knew it was coming. Music and basketball were cousins. Manny could feel that before he could explain it.

Keith did not know any of this at first. Manny kept that world separate. Steve was Manny's place. The records were Manny's secret. The music was something he could own before the neighborhood found it.

But secrets inside small houses never stay hidden forever.

One afternoon, Keith found one of Manny's practice tapes in his room. He pressed play.

The beat came through the speaker.

Keith started talking over it.

Then rhyming.

Then freestyling.

Simple.

Easy.

Like he had been waiting for the beat his whole life.

When Manny walked in, he did not interrupt.

He just stood in the doorway and listened.

By the time Keith looked up, embarrassed, Manny already knew the truth.

Manny had discovered music.

But Keith had discovered his voice.

Episode 6

Night Lights

Everybody had a curfew.

That was the rule in the neighborhood. When the lights came on, you started heading home. Not later. Not after one more game. Not after one more lap around the block. Home.

But rules changed on the nights Ella Mae worked late.

Those nights felt like borrowed time.

Manny and Keith would stand outside longer than they should have. Bikes leaned against fences. Basketballs bounced in driveways. Somebody always had a football. Somebody always wanted to race.

The neighborhood became its own world after dark.

It was not always safe.

But it was alive.

Keith loved those nights. He moved through groups easily, laughing with older boys, learning jokes he was too young to tell, hearing stories he was too young to understand.

Manny watched from a distance, never too far away.

He was older, but not grown. Still, in Keith's life, he was the closest thing to a father figure the boy had every day. That made Manny's childhood heavier. He could not just be outside. He had to monitor the outside.

Kizzy made that job easier and harder at the same time. She barked at anyone who came too close, chased bikes, guarded the porch, and sometimes made more noise than the boys she was supposed to protect.

One Friday, they played until the sky turned purple.

Kickball became stickball.

Stickball became basketball.

Basketball became a bike race.

The day stretched itself as far as it could.

Then the lights came on.

Keith looked at Manny.

Manny looked toward the house.

Ella Mae was still at work.

Keith smiled.

"One more ride?"

Manny should have said no.

Instead, he climbed onto his bike.

"One more."

They rode through the neighborhood like the night belonged to them.

For a little while, it did.

That was the danger of freedom.

It made boys believe they could outrun consequences.

Episode 7

The Move to the Rocks

Ella Mae did not announce the move like a celebration.

She said it like a decision.

"We found a house."

Manny looked up from the table.

Keith stopped chewing.

A house meant something different to a family that had lived in an apartment where footsteps overhead could wake you up and hallway drama could arrive at your door before dinner.

A house meant space.

A basement.

A garage.

A fence.

A yard.

A front door that belonged to them.

It also meant leaving the Woods.

Manny did not know how to feel about that.

He wanted better. He wanted quiet. He wanted his mother to have something that looked like progress.

But the Woods had raised them. Every corner carried a memory. The junkyard. The graveyard. The building. The porch. Steve's turntables across town. Chucky and the boys. Kizzy chasing bikes. Keith laughing under streetlights.

You can move out of a neighborhood.

But you do not move out of what it made you.

The Rocks felt different immediately.

Cleaner streets.

Bigger houses.

More driveways.

People still watched from porches, but they watched differently. Like they were measuring. Like they wanted to know who these new boys were and whether they belonged.

Keith noticed it first.

"They looking at us."

Manny nodded. "Let them look."

"You think they tough?"

Manny looked down the street.

"Everybody tough till they meet somebody from the Woods."

Keith laughed.

The laugh helped.

Still, the Rocks had its own rules. Every neighborhood did. There were boys who felt they controlled the block, boys who tested newcomers just to see if they could be moved.

Manny and Keith did not go looking for trouble.

But they knew how to defend themselves if trouble came looking for them.

Ella Mae's house became the new center of their world.

The garage became a basketball court.

The basement became a place for birthdays, food, and noise.

The fence became a boundary.

The porch became a lookout.

It was better.

It was not innocent.

Nothing ever was.

Episode 8

The Test

Every new neighborhood had a welcoming committee.

Not official.

Not friendly.

Just boys who wanted to know what you were made of.

In the Rocks, they came around slow. A comment here. A shove during a basketball game there. A question that sounded simple but wasn't.

"Where y'all from?"

Manny knew what the question really meant.

Who are you?

What do you know?

Can we push you?

Keith was younger, but he heard the same thing.

"The Woods," Manny answered.

That changed the air.

A few boys looked at each other. The Woods had a reputation, and reputations traveled faster than people.

One afternoon a backyard basketball game turned into more than a game. Hard fouls. Talking. Elbows. One boy kept bumping Keith after the whistle.

Manny stepped between them.

"Play ball."

The boy smirked. "I am."

"Then play."

No one swung.

No one had to.

The message had been delivered.

The Rocks learned something that day. Manny and Keith were not trying to take over anything, but they were not easy prey.

After that, things got smoother.

Not perfect.

Smoother.

Manny started spending more time in driveways with basketball hoops over garage doors. He discovered he was good at street ball, good at using angles, good at finding space where bigger players thought there was none.

Basketball gave him respect in the Rocks.

Music gave him somewhere else to go.

Between the court, Steve's turntables, and the memory of the Woods, Manny was becoming two things at once. Athlete and producer. Big brother and dreamer. Son of a working mother and student of the streets.

Keith watched all of it.

He wanted the crowd.

Manny wanted the craft.

That difference would matter later.

Episode 9

Butch

Manny met Butch in the Rocks even though Butch belonged to the Woods.

That was how the city worked. People had cousins everywhere. A boy from one neighborhood could appear in another like he'd always been there if family gave him a reason.

Butch was visiting people near the Rocks when he and Manny crossed paths outside.

He was dark-skinned, calm, sharp-eyed, and carried himself like he had already seen more than he talked about. He did not try to impress anybody. That made him more noticeable.

Some friendships begin with long conversations.

Theirs began with a basketball.

Butch watched Manny shoot from the driveway.

"You play?" Manny asked.

"Enough."

"That mean you good or you scared?"

Butch smiled.

"Check ball."

The game lasted until the light changed. Neither one gave an inch. Manny played with rhythm and quickness. Butch played with strength and patience. They argued every foul and laughed after every hard shot.

By the end of the game, neither boy had to say they respected the other.

The respect was already there.

Keith liked Butch immediately.

"He cool," Keith told Manny later.

"You say that about everybody."

"Nah. He different."

Keith was right.

Butch loved music too. Not just rap. Guitar. Blues. Rock. Soul. He had a way of hearing sadness inside a chord. Years later, that would become one of the parts of him people forgot to mention when they talked about the streets.

The streets were there too.

Even young, Butch understood money differently. While other boys thought about spending, Butch thought about movement. How something became more. How a connection became opportunity. How loyalty became a network.

Manny saw that and respected it.

Butch saw Manny's discipline and respected that.

They were not brothers by blood.

But life does not always care about blood.

Sometimes it gives you a person and lets time decide the rest.

Episode 10

Lucky's Room

Lucky's studio was not really a studio.

Not at first.

It was a room in a house with equipment squeezed into corners, wires running where they could fit, microphones that worked when they wanted to, and speakers that made every dream sound bigger than it was.

To them, it was everything.

Steve introduced Manny to Lucky, and little by little Steve faded into the background. Steve had been the doorway. Lucky became the room.

Lucky was the same age, but he carried himself like an engineer, producer, mechanic, and dreamer rolled into one. If something broke, he fixed it. If a cable went bad, he found another. If the sound was wrong, he did not complain. He listened until he found the problem.

Manny loved that.

He watched Lucky the way he once watched Steve, but now he was closer to the work. He learned the mixer. The levels. The record crates. The difference between hearing a song and understanding it.

Lucky also kept protection in the studio.

Not because he wanted to be dangerous.

Because people came through houses when music started moving. Strangers. Friends of friends. Boys with talent. Boys with envy. Boys who wanted to hear themselves on tape. Boys who wanted to see what was inside the house.

One afternoon Lucky opened a drawer and Manny saw the gun.

He froze.

Lucky noticed.

"Don't touch it unless you have to."

Manny nodded.

It was the first time he had held one.

The weight stayed in his hand even after Lucky put it away.

That was the studio too. Dreams and danger in the same room. Microphones and protection. Music and reality.

Keith found his place there almost by accident.

A beat came on. Somebody told him to say something. He said he had nothing. Then he started freestyling, and the room changed.

Lucky looked at Manny.

Manny looked back.

Both of them knew.

Keith had something.

The studio became a second home after that. Manny, Keith, Lucky, Butch. Sometimes Cheerio. Sometimes other voices drifting through. Everybody chasing something.

Nobody knew yet how expensive dreams could become.

Episode 11

Dope Fein Dinner

The trap house smelled like charcoal and bad decisions.

Old Man Willie had traded a grill for something he needed more than a grill. That was the kind of exchange the neighborhood understood without anyone writing it down.

The joke started with the food.

Steaks.

Potatoes.

Smoke rising from a grill that had no business being outside that house.

Somebody laughed and called it a dope fiend dinner.

Then somebody else said it was the first mobile delivery service.

"Before Uber."

"Before DoorDash."

The room laughed because the comparison was ridiculous and true in the only way neighborhood jokes had to be true.

Manny stood there taking it all in.

Butch moved through that world differently than he did. More comfortable. More fluent. Not reckless, exactly. Just familiar.

There was humor in the scene, but there was also warning.

The boys were getting older. Their jokes were changing. Their access was changing. Their understanding of money was changing.

A few dollars here.

A favor there.

A package delivered.

A name remembered.

Nothing felt like a fall when it started.

It felt like helping.

It felt like growing up.

It felt like finally having money in your pocket that did not come from asking your mother.

Manny and Butch became partners in small ways first. Nothing flashy. Nothing that looked like empire. Just enough money to buy shoes, help out, move with confidence.

But money has a voice.

Once boys hear it, they rarely forget the sound.

That night, the food tasted better than it should have.

The laughter lasted longer than it needed to.

And somewhere beneath the joke, the Square quietly marked another moment.

Not because anyone died.

Because something innocent did.

Episode 12

The Max Julian

Winter hit the city like punishment.

The kind of cold that made faces hurt and hands disappear into sleeves. Manny stood at the bus stop wearing his Max Julian winter coat with the fur collar pulled close to his neck.

Ella Mae had worked hard for that coat.

It was not just warmth.

It was pride.

A few other people waited near him. A woman. A child. Another boy he did not know. Nobody talked because the cold took up too much space.

Then two older boys crossed the street.

They did not hurry.

That made them worse.

One looked at Manny's coat and smiled.

"Nice Max Julian."

Manny knew then.

Still, part of him hoped he was wrong.

The second boy stepped closer.

"Take it off."

Manny stared at him.

"What?"

The boy lifted his sweatshirt just enough for Manny to see the handle tucked in his waistband.

No speech.

No performance.

Just enough.

Manny unzipped the coat.

His fingers felt far away from his body.

He slid the Max Julian from his shoulders and handed it over.

The cold hit him immediately.

The boys backed away with it and disappeared around the corner.

The bus arrived late.

Nobody spoke.

The boy who had watched everything sat a few rows away. When the bus reached the Woods, he stood and looked back at Manny.

"You alright?"

Manny nodded once.

"Yeah."

The boy nodded.

"My name Nate."

"Manny."

That was all.

No friendship.

No promise.

Just two boys connected by a cold afternoon and something neither of them would forget.

Years later, the neighborhood would know him as Nutty Nate.

But that day, he was just Nate.

A witness.

Sometimes that is how important people enter a life.

Quietly.

Episode 13

Coney Nights

The Coney Island was bright at night.

Neon in the window. Grease on the grill. Fries dropping into hot oil. Booths filled with kids who stayed too long because nobody wanted to go home yet.

Manny, Butch, Lucky, and Keith slid into a booth like they owned it.

They did not have much money, but Coney Island made a few dollars feel like enough. Fries could be shared. Pop could be stretched. Conversations were free.

Outside, somebody started shooting dice near the parking lot.

Nothing big.

Five dollars. Ten dollars. Mostly talking.

Butch laughed and stepped toward the circle. Manny followed. Lucky stayed close enough to watch and far enough to claim he was not involved. Keith floated between everybody, making jokes.

The dice clicked against the concrete.

Money changed hands.

Nobody got rich.

Nobody cared.

Inside, the doorbell rang above the entrance.

Manny looked up.

Nate stood near the counter.

The boy from the bus stop.

Their eyes met.

Nate nodded.

Manny nodded back.

This time, Nate walked over.

"Mind if I sit?"

Butch slid over. "Pull up."

No big introduction. No dramatic speech.

Nate sat down with his food and looked at Manny.

"You probably don't remember me."

Manny smiled.

"I remember."

"The bus stop."

"Yeah."

The table grew quiet for a second.

Nobody asked.

Nobody joked.

Some stories did not need to be retold in public.

Then Keith said something ridiculous about the fries being shorter than his future, and the booth exploded with laughter.

Just like that, Nate was in.

Not officially.

Nothing in the neighborhood was official.

But when they left Coney Island that night and walked toward Lucky's studio, Nate walked with them.

One day it had been four friends.

The next, it was five.

Episode 14

First Day

High school made everything bigger.

Bigger hallways. Bigger crowds. Bigger voices. Bigger chances to disappear.

Manny walked through the front doors and stopped for half a second. Lockers stretched down the hall in both directions. Students moved like traffic. Freshmen tried to look like they knew where they were going. Seniors looked like the building belonged to them.

Butch found him at the lockers.

"You lost?"

"I was."

"You still are."

Manny laughed.

The warning bell rang, but neither moved fast. That was when the hallway changed.

Not silent.

Just aware.

A girl walked toward the lockers carrying books against her chest. Light brown hair. Green eyes. Calm posture. She was not trying to get attention, which made people give it anyway.

She stopped across from them.

"Excuse me."

Manny and Butch stepped aside.

"Thank you."

Her voice was proper without being stiff. Soft without being weak.

Butch looked at Manny after she walked away.

"Who that?"

Manny shrugged.

"I don't know."

"You gonna find out?"

"You are."

Butch grinned.

"Maybe."

Her name was Sarah.

She met Butch first at the lockers. That mattered later. Butch introduced himself with the confidence of someone who made friends easily, and Sarah accepted him with the careful politeness of someone who paid attention before deciding.

Manny watched more than he spoke.

That was his way.

The friendship grew in small pieces. Locker combinations. Lunch tables. Hallway jokes. Basketball practice. Sarah learning the crew. The crew learning Sarah.

She did not judge the Woods.

She did not act impressed by the Rocks.

She listened.

That made her different.

By the time she asked about Lucky's studio, she was already part of the story. She just did not know how deeply.

Episode 15

Sarah

Sarah stepped into Lucky's studio and looked around like she had entered a museum made by teenagers.

Cassettes stacked near the wall.

Handwritten lyrics.

A mixer that looked complicated because it was.

Microphones that had carried more dreams than finished songs.

Lucky watched her reaction carefully.

"What you think?"

Sarah smiled.

"I think it's perfect."

Lucky laughed. "It ain't perfect."

"No," she said. "But it's yours."

That answer stayed with him.

Butch watched Sarah watch the room. He liked that she did not make fun of anything. She did not ask why the walls were small or why the equipment was mismatched. She understood that what mattered was not how polished the place looked.

It was what happened inside it.

Keith tried to avoid rapping in front of her.

That lasted less than a minute.

Lucky dropped a beat. Somebody laughed. Keith said he wasn't doing it. Then the rhythm pulled him in anyway.

Sarah listened without interrupting.

When he finished, she looked at him.

"You really don't write?"

Keith shrugged. "Nah."

"That's incredible."

He looked embarrassed.

Manny smiled proudly. "I heard it before anybody."

Sarah looked around the room. Manny the basketball player and producer. Butch with music in his bones and money in his mind. Lucky building sound from scraps. Keith speaking thoughts into rhythm. Nate quiet, present, watching.

"None of you know how talented you are," she said.

Nobody answered because nobody believed her yet.

Butch walked her home later.

He did not rush the moment.

Sarah noticed.

That was another thing she liked.

Over time, she and Butch became close in a way that felt natural. He made her laugh. She made him softer without asking him to change. Manny saw it and respected it.

There was no betrayal in that.

Just youth.

Just timing.

Just three lives beginning to tie themselves together before any of them understood how hard the knots would be to untangle.

Episode 16

The Fallen

Fall came with birds in the sky.

Long black lines crossing over the city every morning, moving together toward somewhere warmer. Manny watched them from Ella Mae's porch and wondered how they always knew when to leave.

Butch stood beside him.

"Birds of a feather," Manny said.

Butch looked up.

"They stay together."

The season changed everything slowly.

Leaves fell.

The air sharpened.

Basketball moved from long afternoons to whatever daylight remained after school. Music got louder because windows closed and rooms held sound better. Conversations shifted from games to money, cars, girls, and what came next.

Manny and Butch had quietly become partners in more than friendship.

Small street money.

Errands.

Connections.

Nothing that looked huge yet. Just enough to put cash in their pockets and make them feel older than sixteen.

Butch counted a small roll one evening and split it evenly.

"Half yours."

Manny looked at it.

"You sure?"

"We partners."

Manny took the money.

Partners shared profit.

They also shared risk.

Neither boy understood that part yet.

Keith still lived in a different world. Rapping, joking, floating through crowds. Manny tried to keep him there as long as possible. He wanted his little brother to enjoy being young before the streets taught him the price of being noticed.

But the world was already watching Keith.

The world was watching all of them.

Fall meant leaves falling, birds leaving, innocence thinning.

The title did not mean someone had fallen yet.

It meant the falling had begun.

Episode 17

The Invitation

The Sweet Sixteen was not printed on invitations.

It moved by mouth.

Manny's birthday.

Ella Mae's house.

Music in the backyard.

Food and gifts in the basement.

Lucky on the turntables.

Uncle Candyman keeping order because Ella Mae had to work.

Everybody knew.

By Friday, the school hallways were full of it.

"You going?"

"What you wearing?"

"I heard Lucky bringing speakers."

"I heard everybody from the Woods coming."

"I heard the Rocks too."

The story grew every time someone told it.

Sarah had never been to a party like that.

Butch smiled when she said it.

"Then you gotta come."

"Is that an invitation?"

"That was the invitation."

She laughed.

Manny invited Chucky through Keith, or maybe Keith invited Chucky because Keith invited everybody without thinking about what it meant to include someone fully. Chucky heard it as something bigger. He heard it like a promise.

That mattered later.

Saturday morning, Manny helped Ella Mae before she left for work. She looked around the house like she was trusting him with more than walls and furniture.

"No drama," she said.

Manny nodded.

"No streets in my house."

"I know, Ma."

She looked at Keith.

"And you."

Keith smiled too fast.

"Yes, Ma."

Uncle Candyman arrived later, looked at the backyard, the basement, the garage, and the boys hauling speakers.

"Y'all have fun," he said. "Just don't make me earn my paycheck tonight."

Everybody laughed.

No one knew how much those words would weigh before morning.

Episode 18

The Chocolate Cake

The party began in pieces.

First the backyard lights.

Then the speakers.

Then Lucky testing sound beneath the open night.

Then food downstairs in the basement, where tables held pans, chips, pop, gifts, and the birthday cake.

The main floor stayed mostly off-limits except for the bathroom. The real party had two hearts. The basement held the food and gifts. The backyard held the music.

As the night grew, the music won.

People drifted outside and stayed there.

Lucky moved between West Coast and East Coast records like he was controlling the weather. Every switch changed the yard. Some songs made people shout. Some made them dance. Some made them remember.

Cheerio took the microphone first.

Then Keith.

Keith said he had nothing, like always.

Then he gave them everything.

No paper. No notebook. Just breath and rhythm.

The backyard erupted.

Lucky tried to pass the microphone to Butch. Butch laughed and pushed it away.

"I sing. I don't rap."

He passed it to Manny.

Manny laughed too.

"Y'all crazy."

That was the kind of night it was.

In the basement, people brought gifts.

A shirt. A basketball. Cash folded inside cards. Small things that felt big because they came from people who cared.

Then Sarah stepped forward with a white box.

"Happy birthday."

Manny opened it.

A homemade chocolate cake.

Not store-bought.

Made.

Chocolate icing. Careful letters.

Happy 16th Manny.

"You made this?" he asked.

Sarah smiled. "I did."

One of Manny's girl cousins leaned over his shoulder and grinned.

"Ooooo. She like you."

The basement exploded with laughter.

Sarah's face warmed.

"I just wanted him to have something personal."

The cousin laughed harder.

"Personal. Mmm-hmm."

Manny looked at Sarah and smiled.

"Nobody ever baked me a cake before."

Sarah's smile softened.

"Now somebody has."

For a moment, the whole basement felt warmer.

Then the backyard music pulled everybody outside again.

The cake stayed behind on the table like a quiet secret.

Episode 19

The Backyard

By late night, the backyard had become its own city.

Lucky's DJ table sat beneath the backyard light. Speakers stood near the fence. Extension cords ran carefully through the grass. Milk crates full of records rested near his feet.

The basement was for eating.

The backyard was for living.

Nutty Nate brought the alcohol and moved through the party like a man who believed every cup had a story. Some drinks were stronger than people expected. He warned them with a grin.

"Easy. It'll sneak up on you."

Most did not listen.

The basketball team slipped behind the garage to smoke. They thought they were hidden until Uncle Candyman stepped around the corner.

"What y'all smoking?"

The boys froze.

One tried to hide it.

Candyman held out his hand.

"Let me see."

He looked at it, shook his head, and laughed.

"This some bullshit."

The boys burst out laughing, unsure if they were safe or in trouble.

Candyman reached into his jacket and pulled out his own bag.

"If y'all want real weed, this what you want. Fifty dollars."

They laughed until they realized he was serious.

Somebody paid.

Candyman walked back toward the party like nothing happened.

That was Candyman. Chaperone, uncle, neighborhood man, street philosopher, and the only adult Ella Mae trusted enough to watch her house while she worked.

Later, people snuck into the bathroom together and got caught. They came out trying to look innocent while the hallway laughed them back outside.

The freaks came out at night.

Somebody said it.

Everybody laughed because by then the party was loose enough for the truth to be funny.

Manny started cleaning the basement because it was his mother's house. Sarah noticed and helped. They stacked plates, moved gifts, saved the rest of her chocolate cake, and cleared the tables while the music kept pulling people outside.

For a few minutes, they were the last two downstairs.

Then Butch came down and helped too.

It was not jealousy.

It was friendship.

A quiet moment passed between Manny and Sarah, something both felt and neither touched. They laughed it off and kept cleaning.

Outside, the music got louder.

Last Dance had begun before anyone knew that was what it would become.

Episode 20

Last Dance

Around 11:30, Manny thought the party might shut down by one.

He was wrong.

People left in waves.

The basketball team left early. Most of the family left. Cousins got pulled into cars. Younger kids fell asleep before they reached the corner.

The people who stayed were the ones who wanted to get lit.

By 12:35, the birthday party had become an after-party.

Manny climbed onto Lucky's DJ table and reached past the hip-hop records. He dug into the crate and pulled out funk.

Lucky saw the record and laughed.

"You going there?"

Manny smiled.

"Watch."

The needle dropped.

The backyard exploded.

People who had been sitting jumped up. People who had been leaving turned around. The funk woke the yard back up and made everyone forget how late it was.

Chucky had spent most of the night feeling out of place. Keith had invited him, but Keith kept getting pulled into the party. Freestyles, jokes, helping his brother, moving through the crowd. Chucky took it personal because lonely people often hear absence as rejection.

Butch checked on him first because Uncle Candyman noticed. Then Sarah saw Butch had already spoken to him and decided to try too. She introduced him to Michelle, a girl about his height who made him feel comfortable.

At first Michelle danced with Chucky because Sarah sent her.

Then she kept dancing because she liked him.

Chucky bragged a little about making money. He promised to take her shopping for gym shoes. Michelle could not believe he was serious.

"Next Saturday," he said.

She gave him a kiss on the cheek.

For a while, Chucky had exactly what he wanted.

A place.

A person.

A smile that was not forced.

Then somebody teased. Not cruelly. Just party talk. But the whole night had made Chucky sensitive to laughter.

Still, the party continued.

A girl got sick. Butch volunteered to take her home safely. Sarah trusted him because that was Butch. He left for a short while and returned to find the party still alive.

By 1:30, the food and drinks were gone. Chucky joked that if he had known they would run out, he would have bought more. It was a bad joke, too close to showing off, but Keith laughed it off and the awkwardness passed.

By 2:00, Lucky said this was the last song.

Nobody believed him.

Uncle Candyman gave him one finger.

One more.

The final record spun. People danced. Others cleaned. Manny picked up cups because Ella Mae had trusted him with her house.

For one perfect breath, the night seemed saved.

Then the music faded.

And the last song ended.

Episode 21

Bloody Sweet 16

NARRATOR:

Everybody thinks a birthday party is supposed to end with candles, pictures, and somebody saying they had a good time.

But some nights do not end. They split your life in half.

Before and after.

Before the rain.

Before the concrete.

Before the whole neighborhood learned that childhood can die without asking permission.

At first, Manny's Sweet Sixteen was safe. That was what everybody would remember later, even the ones who lied about the rest. The first half of the night had music, food, laughing, dancing, and grown folks standing close enough to pretend they had control.

Ella Mae's house sat on the Rocks like it had dressed itself up for company. The backyard lights glowed against the fence. Smoke from the grill lifted slow into the warm air. The basement door kept opening and closing as cousins, neighbors, and friends moved through the house with plates in their hands and music in their bodies.

Manny tried to act like it was just another night, but he could feel everybody looking at him. Sixteen had a weight to it. Old enough to be watched like a man. Young enough to still want somebody to make sure the party went right.

Keith was everywhere at once. Laughing near the speakers. Dancing when Lucky changed records. Grabbing cups before somebody else took the last of the punch. He had that glow around him, the kind that made people forget he was still a kid.

Chucky came in quieter than usual. He smiled when people spoke, but he kept checking where Keith was. Not every second. Just enough. Like he was measuring the distance between them and trying not to admit it hurt.

For a while, nobody noticed.

The party was still bright then.

Safe.

Sarah arrived with Butch near the side gate, and the whole backyard seemed to make room for them without being asked. She wore her confidence like it had been tailored for her. Not loud. Not forced. Just present.

Butch stayed close to her shoulder, proud and restless at the same time. He was from the Woods, but he carried himself like he could stand anywhere and make the ground belong to him. Tonight, though, Sarah had him softened around the edges.

"You look good," Butch said.

Sarah smiled. "Thank you."

"I mean real good."

"I heard you the first time."

He leaned closer, testing the space between them. His voice dropped low enough that nobody else was supposed to hear.

"Come around the side with me for a minute."

Sarah looked at him, amused. "For what?"

"You know for what."

She touched his wrist gently and shook her head.

"Not here."

"Ain't nobody gonna see us."

"Butch."

The way she said his name stopped him. Not harsh. Not scared. Just certain.

"Not here," she repeated.

Butch smiled, but he respected it. That was the part Manny noticed from across the yard. Sarah did not have to get loud to hold her ground. She did not embarrass Butch. She did not flirt with danger just to prove she could. She gave him a boundary and left him his pride.

Manny watched longer than he meant to.

He already knew Sarah was pretty. Everybody knew that. But that night he saw something else. The way she moved through noise without becoming noise. The way she looked at people when they talked, like she was actually listening. The way she smiled at Butch and still kept herself whole.

That bothered him.

Not because he wanted it to.

Because he knew she was talking to his boy.

Manny turned away and pretended to check on the drinks.

Then he looked back.

CHECK CHECK - 8:42 P.M.

Nutty Nate: Party smooth so far.

Lucky: So far?

Nutty Nate: I said what I said.

Cheerio: Nate already drunk.

Nutty Nate: I ain't drunk. I am elevated.

Nutty Nate had started the night funny. That was the problem. Funny could turn into annoying before anybody knew where the line was. He talked over songs. He corrected stories nobody asked him to correct. He walked from group to group like the party needed his commentary to stay alive.

At first, people laughed.

Then they started looking away when he came near.

Nate did not take the hint.

"Who want a contest?" he shouted, holding up a cup.

Lucky looked over from the records. "A contest for what?"

"Drinking."

Cheerio laughed. "That ain't no contest. That's how somebody throw up in Ella Mae yard."

"Man, y'all soft on the Rocks."

That got a few heads to turn.

The Rocks boys laughed like it was nothing. The Woods boys did not all laugh. Some of them had been standing around for too long, leaning against the fence, waiting for something more exciting than birthday cake and family music.

One of Butch's homeboys, D-Lo, shook his head and looked toward the street.

"This what y'all do over here?" D-Lo asked. "Stand around and clap?"

Another one laughed. "I told you the Rocks was church with better shoes."

Butch heard it and gave them a look.

"Chill," he said.

"We chilling," D-Lo answered. "That's the problem."

Sarah felt Butch tense beside her. She slid her hand into his for half a second. Not romantic enough for the crowd to notice. Just enough for him.

Butch breathed through his nose and let it go.

Manny saw that too.

Sarah had a way of changing the temperature around a man without making a speech.

By the time the sun went all the way down, the party had a different face.

The little kids were inside. The grown folks were tired. The music got heavier. The jokes got sharper. Cups were not being watched as closely. People who had been dancing earlier were now standing in corners, studying each other.

Dark did not create the drama.

Dark only gave it permission.

Nate made his way toward Chucky with a grin that already had too much gasoline in it.

"Chuck, why you standing over here looking like somebody stole your bike?"

Chucky glanced at him. "Move around, Nate."

"I am moving around. That's how I found you over here by yourself."

A few people laughed. Not hard. Just enough to make Chucky's face change.

"I said move around."

"Damn. You sensitive tonight."

Keith was near the speakers, laughing with two girls and showing them how to catch the beat before it dropped. He did not hear Nate. He did not see Chucky look over at him.

That was the small thing that became a big thing.

Chucky waited for Keith to notice.

Keith did not.

Nate kept talking.

"You mad cause Keith famous now?" Nate said.

Chucky looked at him slowly.

"What?"

"I said you mad cause your boy getting attention."

Michelle stepped between them. "Nate, leave him alone."

"I ain't doing nothing. I'm talking."

"You always talking," Michelle said.

Nate laughed too loud.

"That's cause I got words. Some of y'all just got feelings."

Chucky stepped forward, but Michelle touched his chest.

"Don't," she said quietly.

He looked at her. For one second, he almost listened.

Then Keith finally looked over.

Not with concern.

With confusion.

Like he was late to a conversation that had already been hurting somebody.

Manny was in the kitchen when Sarah came in for water.

The house was cooler than the backyard. The music came through the walls as a muffled pulse. For the first time all night, Sarah looked a little tired.

"You good?" Manny asked.

She nodded. "I am. Just needed a second."

"Party too much?"

"The party is fine."

She looked through the window toward the yard.

"People are what get complicated."

Manny smiled because he understood that more than he wanted to.

"Butch getting on your nerves?"

Sarah smiled without looking at him.

"Butch is Butch."

"That ain't an answer."

"It is if you know him."

Manny leaned against the counter. He should have left it there. He knew that. But her voice had a calm pull to it. It made him want to keep talking.

"You handle him good."

Sarah looked at him then.

"He does not need to be handled. He needs to be understood."

Manny felt that line sit in his chest.

"You always talk like that?"

"Like what?"

"Like you older than everybody."

She laughed softly.

"Maybe everybody else acts younger than they should."

For a second, neither one said anything.

Manny knew exactly where Butch was. Outside. His boy. His friend. A person he trusted.

That did not stop the thought from coming.

Sarah was different.

He looked away first.

"You should get back out there," he said.

"So should you. It is your birthday."

She picked up the water and walked past him. Her shoulder almost touched his arm, but did not.

Manny stood in the kitchen for a moment after she left, hating himself a little because he watched her go.

CHECK CHECK - 10:19 P.M.

Cheerio: Nate about to get punched before midnight.

Lucky: By who?

Cheerio: Everybody.

Nutty Nate: I see my name in this chat.

Lucky: Then act right.

Nutty Nate: Make me.

By ten-thirty, the party was still alive, but it was not innocent anymore.

D-Lo and the Woods boys had moved closer to the driveway. They were bored, and bored street boys made boredom everybody's problem. They wanted a dice game. Then they wanted somebody to race down the block. Then they wanted to know why the Rocks boys kept looking at them like they did not belong.

Butch kept stepping in before words became hands.

"Y'all here with me," he told them. "Do not make me regret that."

D-Lo smirked. "You sound like somebody uncle."

"And you sound like somebody who need to go home."

Sarah stood beside Butch again. This time she did not touch him. She only looked at him, and that was enough to tell him not to chase every spark.

Butch lowered his voice.

"You see what I be dealing with?"

"I see what you choose to deal with," Sarah said.

He laughed despite himself.

"You always got something smart to say."

"Only when it helps."

He leaned in again, his mouth close to her ear.

"Then help me get five minutes alone."

Sarah did not move away, but she did not give in either.

"Not here."

"You killing me."

"You will live."

Butch smiled down at her like he wanted to argue, but he liked her too much for that. He settled for brushing his thumb across the back of her hand.

Manny saw it from the porch.

Then he saw Sarah pull Butch back toward calm without making him feel weak.

He could not keep his mind off her.

And that made him angry at himself.

A little later, the rain threatened the party without ending it.

At first, everybody thought the weather had saved the night. Rain meant the backyard had to shut down. Rain meant people had to move under the porch, into the garage, and down toward the basement where the music could keep playing without the whole block watching.

It should have made things safer.

It did not.

The basement made the party smaller, hotter, and louder. The older boys packed near the walls. The girls stood closer to the steps. Every laugh felt like it had less room to escape.

Chucky followed the older boys down there like he belonged with them.

He was thirteen, but nobody guessed it right away. He was big for his age, broad enough in the shoulders and serious enough in the face that he could pass for fifteen or sixteen if nobody asked too many questions.

That was what he wanted.

To pass.

To be seen as one of them.

To stand near boys who already sounded like men and not have anybody notice the difference.

The girl he liked was near the basement wall with a cup in her hand. She had smiled at him twice that night, and both times Chucky had walked away feeling taller.

Now she looked him over with a playful little smile.

"What school you go to?" she asked.

Chucky froze for half a second.

It was not a hard question.

That was what made it dangerous.

"I ain't over there yet," he said.

The girl blinked.

"You not in high school?"

Somebody nearby heard it and laughed before they could stop themselves.

Chucky's face changed.

Not all at once.

Just enough.

His shoulders lifted. His jaw locked. The boy in him got exposed in front of the older boys, and the man he was trying to pretend to be had nowhere to hide.

The girl did not mean to hurt him.

That almost made it worse.

"I thought you was older," she said softly.

Chucky forced a smile.

"Everybody do."

He stepped away before she could say anything else.

From that point on, he was not just quiet.

He was looking for a way to get his size back.

Nate saw it.

And Nate, being Nate, could not leave it alone.

Near midnight, Nate started the drinking contest anyway.

It was loud, stupid, and exactly what the bored ones wanted. Cups lined the edge of a folding table. Half the people cheered. The other half told them to cut it out while still watching.

Chucky tried to stay away from it.

Nate would not let him.

"Chuck, come take one."

"I'm cool."

"You always cool. Be something else for once."

Keith finally stepped over. "Nate, quit messing with him."

Nate lifted both hands. "Look who showed up."

Chucky looked at Keith, and for one second the hurt almost showed plainly enough for Keith to understand it.

But Nate kept talking.

"Now Keith care. Took you long enough."

Keith frowned. "What that supposed to mean?"

Chucky said, "Leave it alone."

"Nah," Nate said. "Let him ask. Everybody been seeing it."

The circle tightened.

Manny came off the porch.

"Seeing what?" Keith asked.

"That your boy been sitting over there all night waiting on you like a sad puppy."

Chucky shoved Nate before anybody could stop him.

It was not hard enough to start a fight by itself. But it was hard enough to make the yard gasp.

Nate stumbled back and laughed, embarrassed.

"See? Sensitive."

Keith grabbed Chucky's arm.

"Man, what you doing?"

Chucky snatched away.

"Now you see me?"

The words hit Keith in the face harder than a punch.

"What?"

"I said now you see me?"

Manny stepped between them.

"Not tonight," he said.

Uncle Candyman came from the driveway with his voice already raised.

"Everybody back up. Right now."

For a moment, the grown folks won. The circle broke. Lucky cut the record and switched to something slower. Michelle walked Chucky toward the side fence. Sarah pulled Butch away from D-Lo and the Woods boys before they could turn the moment into entertainment.

It looked handled.

That was the lie the night told everybody.

CHECK CHECK - 12:08 A.M.

Lucky: Everybody chill.

Cheerio: That was close.

Nutty Nate: Wasn't even serious.

Michelle: Stop talking.

Nutty Nate: Damn.

After midnight, the party tried to become safe again.

That was the saddest part.

People danced. People laughed too loud. People cleaned plates and pretended the air did not still taste like a fight. Manny opened gifts he barely remembered. Keith rapped when Lucky put on an instrumental, and for three minutes the whole yard loved him again.

Chucky watched from near the fence.

Michelle stood beside him.

"He ain't doing it to hurt you," she said.

"You don't know what he doing."

"Maybe he don't either."

Chucky looked at her then. The line made too much sense, and he hated it.

"I just wanted my friend tonight."

Michelle's face softened.

"Then tell him that. Not Nate. Not everybody else. Him."

Chucky looked back at Keith, who was laughing beside Manny now, arm thrown over his brother's shoulder.

"He should already know."

Michelle did not have an answer for that.

By one, the rain came down hard with no warning.

Not a sprinkle. Not a warning tap on the leaves. It dropped out of the sky like somebody had opened a door above the house and poured the night through it.

Girls screamed and ran for the porch. Boys grabbed speakers, records, cups, jackets, anything they could reach. Somebody slipped near the grass and got laughed at before anybody checked if they were hurt. The backyard lights shook in the rain. The grill hissed. The music warped and crackled while Lucky yelled for somebody to help him move the crates.

It should have made everything safe.

Rain meant the outside party was over. Rain meant people had to go home, or at least move inside and calm down. Rain should have broken the spell.

Instead, everybody crashed out at the same time.

The porch filled first. Then the garage. Then the basement steps became a jam of wet bodies, shouting voices, perfume, weed smoke, spilled punch, and somebody yelling, "Move!" even though there was nowhere to move to.

Everybody could not fit in the basement.

That did not stop everybody from trying.

Manny, Butch, Sarah, and Keith got pushed upstairs with half the crowd while the basement swallowed the rest. The house started sounding different. Not like a party anymore. Like a place being tested.

A girl screamed because somebody stepped on her shoe. Somebody else knocked a picture crooked on the wall. D-Lo and the Woods boys laughed too hard near the stairs. Nate kept talking over everybody, feeding the panic because attention was still attention, even when it was ugly.

Crash-out moved through the house like smoke.

One person got loud, then another. One shove became three. One joke became disrespect. The rain had forced everybody closer, and close was exactly what the night did not need.

Manny looked around at the cups on the floor, the wet footprints, the bodies pressing through the hallway, and the way people were leaning on his mother's walls like the house belonged to them.

The next day was Sunday.

That did not matter. He could not have everybody spend the night. He could not let Ella Mae wake up to a house that looked like strangers had fought inside it.

When the rain slowed, Manny snapped.

"Everybody gotta go!"

The hallway quieted just enough to hear him.

"Party over. Y'all got to go."

Somebody groaned. "Man, it's still raining."

"Then get wet," Manny said. "Y'all not about to trash this house."

It came out sharper than he meant, but he did not take it back.

Butch looked at him and nodded once, like he understood. Sarah stayed near the wall, watching Manny with a different kind of quiet. Keith stood by the basement door, still damp from the rain, still trying to read Chucky's face.

Chucky was in the corner near the side door, talking low with Keith about something that had started small and stayed small only because neither one had raised his voice yet.

People started moving toward the exits, but slowly. Nobody wanted to leave. Not really. The rain had slowed, the party was over, and still everybody could feel that something had not finished.

Chucky stepped toward the door first.

His shoulder brushed past Keith.

Then he said something low.

A smart remark. Quiet enough to pretend it was not meant for the room. Loud enough for Keith to hear it.

Keith's head turned.

"Dog, what did you just say?"

Chucky kept walking.

"You heard me."

He reached for the door.

"I don't gotta repeat myself."

Keith stared at the back of his head.

The hallway went still.

"Hold on," Keith said. "Wait a minute. I'm coming out."

That was all the crowd needed.

The same people who had complained about the rain suddenly forgot they were wet. They followed the two boys toward the front like the fight was part of the party, like they wanted it and were ashamed of wanting it at the same time.

Manny moved after them.

Butch moved faster.

Sarah grabbed Butch's sleeve.

"Do not let this happen."

But the house was already spilling outside.

Lucky's needle circled the end of the record downstairs.

Scratch.

Scratch.

Scratch.

CHECK CHECK - 1:57 A.M.

Nutty Nate: They back at it.

Lucky: Who?

Nutty Nate: Keith and Chuck.

Michelle: Nate stop texting and help.

Nutty Nate: I ain't in it.

Michelle: You started half of it.

Outside, the rain had slowed to a cold mist, but the driveway was still slick and shining.

The crowd circled too fast. Nobody said they wanted a fight, but nobody backed away like they wanted peace either.

Chucky turned around near the front walk.

"What you coming out here for?"

"You said something," Keith said.

"And?"

"And I asked you what you said."

"And I told you I ain't repeating myself."

Keith stepped closer.

"You trying to look tough now?"

That was the wrong thing to say to a thirteen-year-old boy who had spent the whole night trying to prove he was older than he was.

Chucky shoved him first.

Hard.

Keith slid back on the wet concrete, and the crowd made that sound crowds make when they know a line just got crossed.

"Oh!"

Keith came forward, but Chucky was already on him. He used his size, his weight, all that big-for-his-age strength he had been carrying around like borrowed armor. He pushed Keith into the grass, swung wild, grabbed at his shirt, and for the first few seconds it looked like Chucky had him.

That made the crowd louder.

Too loud.

Girls shouted. Boys jumped back and then leaned in. Somebody yelled, "Get him!" and somebody else yelled, "Break it up!" but both voices sounded like the same kind of excitement.

"Keith!" Manny shouted.

"Chucky!" Michelle screamed.

Butch cut through the circle with Sarah right behind him.

"Break that shit up!" Butch barked.

Uncle Candyman came off the driveway like a man who had broken up too many fights in his life and already knew this one felt different.

"Enough!" Candyman yelled. "Both of y'all, enough!"

Nobody heard him the way they needed to.

Chucky got one more shove in and turned his back like he had proved his point. He did not realize Keith had reached his limit. He did not realize the fight had changed shape behind him.

Keith grabbed him around the waist.

Chucky's feet came off the wet ground.

Chucky fought to twist out. "Get off me!"

Keith held tighter.

"Then quit swinging!"

They stumbled toward the concrete edge where the driveway met the walkway. The porch light flickered once. Rain splashed off their shoulders. Everybody was running toward them, but everybody was one second too late.

Sarah saw Keith's feet set.

She saw Chucky's body lift.

She saw the whole future open its mouth.

"No!"

Keith turned with him.

Not clean. Not like a move from a fight somebody practiced.

Ugly.

Desperate.

Too much strength in the wrong moment.

He slammed Chucky onto the driveway.

The sound split the night.

Concrete. Bone. Rain.

A hard, flat crack that made every person there feel it in their teeth.

Then silence.

The kind of silence that does not mean peace.

The kind that means everybody knows something just crossed over and is not coming back.

Keith let go and stumbled backward.

Chucky lay on the driveway, twisted halfway toward the porch, his cheek pressed to the wet concrete. Rain ran over his face and down into the cracks. A dark red line opened beneath him and spread thin through the water, crawling toward the gutter like the driveway itself was trying to carry the secret away.

Michelle screamed so hard her voice broke.

"Chucky!"

Manny dropped to his knees beside him.

"Chuck! Chuck, look at me!"

Chucky did not answer.

His eyes were open enough to make hope cruel.

Keith stared down at him. His hands hung in front of his body, fingers spread, rain dripping from his knuckles.

"I ain't mean..."

Nobody looked at him.

"I ain't mean to do that."

Butch grabbed Keith by the shirt and pulled him back before someone else did it worse.

"Move," Butch said. "Back up. Back the hell up."

Keith did not fight him. His legs barely worked.

Sarah stood under the rain with both hands over her mouth, shaking her head before her mind could even form the truth.

Uncle Candyman pushed through the circle.

"Call 911!"

No one moved.

"Now!"

Phones came out with trembling hands. Somebody cried. Somebody cursed. Somebody kept saying, "Damn, damn, damn," like repetition could become a prayer.

Red and blue lights arrived before the house had found its voice again.

Police stepped into the rain asking questions nobody wanted to answer.

"What happened?" one officer asked.

The crowd looked at Keith.

Keith looked like his soul had left his body and forgot to take him with it.

Butch stepped forward before Keith could open his mouth.

"He was running," Butch said.

The officer looked at him.

"Who was running?"

"Chucky," Butch said. "He was running. He slipped on the curb."

The lie hit the driveway and stayed there.

Nobody corrected it.

Not yet.

Keith stood behind Butch with rain running down his face, understanding just enough to know he had been pulled away from the first door that could have closed on his life.

No one said the word murder.

No one had to.

Lucky's record was still scratching in the backyard.

Scratch.

Scratch.

Scratch.

The beat was gone. Only the wound remained.

Nate looked down at his phone.

CHECK CHECK - 1:59 A.M.

Lucky: What happened?

Cheerio: Nate?

Lucky: What happened?

Nutty Nate is typing...

Nutty Nate stopped typing.

There were no words for it.

Not in the chat.

Not in the street.

Not in Manny's mouth.

The birthday banner tore loose from one side of the porch and slapped against the railing. Balloons jerked in the wind. One broke free and rolled across the wet street until the darkness swallowed it.

Above the rooftops, large blackbirds cut across the night sky.

Not many.

Just enough to make the darkness feel alive.

Their wings moved through the rain, wide and crow-like, black signs nobody knew how to read yet.

Manny stood in his room.

Rain tapped against the window.

His shirt clung cold to his back.

The house was dark except for the alarm clock glowing red beside his bed.

2:00 A.M.

Manny stared at it.

Outside, somewhere far away, a siren kept rising.

The red numbers did not move.

2:00 A.M.